

Five Steps to Financial Wellbeing

and bad. Having to pay close attention to every single thing that came in and went out of my account, and having to have conversations about rates and fees, helped me to engage with my finances and to feel less awkward talking about money. I started to realize that there wasn't really a cap on my earnings as there had been when I was employed – something which, most self-employed people will agree, can be both a blessing and a curse.

For all the benefits of earning and engaging with money in a new way, and for all the relief I felt as I moved away from the frustrations of trying to progress in my career according to somebody else's terms, there were new challenges. For the first time ever, *I* was the one deciding what my work was worth, and setting my rates was something I struggled with for a long time – as lots of freelancers do. Even though I was earning more per unit of my time, I felt that my self-worth was even more tied to my earnings than ever before, and I struggled to say no to work or safeguard any of my personal time. I started to see my minutes and hours for their cash value, and any moment that I wasn't working was a missed opportunity to pay a little more off my debt, or to put a little extra into an emergency fund. I also experienced the typical freelancer anxiety around turning down any opportunity, in case it was the last one.

Then, there was the fear of 'selling out'. I was finally – after years of earning a salary in marketing and feeling increasingly guilty about contributing to a problem that I myself was